

Research brief: a weekly opportunities letter for mid-career analysts

Prepared for: Dave Holmes-Kinsella
Date: 9 August 2026
Working concept: A free weekly letter curating opportunities shared through Dave’s network, intended to help mid-career data analysts and analytics engineers find work suited to their careers and values.

Executive conclusion

There is no shortage of data jobs, specialist job boards, alerts or career content. The defensible opportunity is not to build a better database. It is to publish a small, trusted letter that answers a more human question:

Which opportunities reaching this particular network seem worth the attention of experienced analysts—and why?

The durable assets are the relationships that generate opportunities, Dave’s accumulated judgment about analytics work and organizations, the trust of readers, and a permission-based email list. The individual listings are perishable. The archive, software and formatting are secondary.

Dave’s taste should not be treated as an awkward subjective layer to remove. It is the product. The important discipline is to make that taste legible: distinguish facts from impressions, explain why something made the cut, and never imply that an employer has been vetted when the evidence is only a referral or a job description.

The strongest positioning is therefore:

A free weekly note for mid-career data analysts and analytics engineers, featuring a small selection of opportunities shared through my network—with context on the work, the organization and why each one may be worth your attention.

The market around the idea

The adjacent market falls into five recognizable models.

Model	Representative examples	What it does well	Why it does not own this idea
High-volume general marketplace	LinkedIn, Indeed	Breadth, search, alerts and application flow	Volume creates noise; the relationship behind a listing is normally invisible
Role-specific job board	DataAnalyst.com , Analytics Engineering Jobs	Normalized filters, salaries, seniority and technical tags	Its unit of value is still a listing, not a trusted introduction or a curator’s interpretation
Curated professional newsletter	Data Elixir	A habitual weekly relationship and a recognizable editorial voice	Primarily learning and industry content rather than network-sourced career opportunities
Culture- or mission-oriented marketplace	Welcome to the Jungle , Tech Jobs for Good	Makes company culture, mission or impact part of discovery	Uses platform-scale profiles and matching; values are categories rather than personal judgment

Model	Representative examples	What it does well	Why it does not own this idea
Peer job-search community	Never Search Alone , Locally Optimistic	Trust, mutual aid, accountability and practitioner community	Community is the primary service; neither is a concise, personally curated weekly opportunity letter for this specific audience

What the examples show

- **Role specificity is useful but insufficient.** Analytics Engineering Jobs already offers a curated board with seniority, salary and stack tags. DataAnalyst.com segments alerts by career level and publishes market insights. Competing on classification would mean recreating an existing commodity.
- **People want less noise, not another source of volume.** Welcome to the Jungle explicitly markets relevant matching and richer company context as an alternative to endless scrolling. Your version can deliver that benefit through human selection rather than a matching system.
- **Values can create a market boundary.** Tech Jobs for Good demonstrates that mission can be a primary discovery axis. Your letter need not be limited to nonprofits or social-impact employers, but it can take the quality and consequences of the work seriously.
- **Community makes a search emotionally and practically better.** Never Search Alone is built around the proposition that job seekers benefit from support, confidence and shared process. Locally Optimistic describes its analytics community as a practitioner “brain trust.” Your letter can carry some of that humanity without becoming a coaching program or Slack community.

What is durable

1. A network that supplies opportunities before or alongside mass distribution

The strongest input is not a scraped posting. It is a message from a former colleague, hiring manager, founder, investor or practitioner saying, “We are looking for someone good.” That carries context and permits a useful follow-up question.

This advantage is durable only if the letter gives something back to the network: thoughtful candidates, accurate representation of the role, gratitude, and evidence that sharing with you is worthwhile.

2. Judgment accumulated through doing and leading the work

Job titles in this field remain blurry. dbt’s own career guidance notes that analytics-engineering work is often hidden inside analyst or data-engineer titles, so candidates must evaluate the work rather than rely on the label ([dbt Labs](#)). Dave can interpret the actual shape of a role: decision support, stakeholder partnership, metric design, modeling, platform work, team building or dashboard production.

That judgment compounds. A taxonomy or scraper can be copied; decades of pattern recognition cannot be copied quickly.

3. Reader trust

Trust will come from restraint:

- Publish five good opportunities rather than padding an issue to fifteen.
- Say exactly what is known and how it is known.
- Include a role because it may serve the reader, not because the employer paid.
- Correct errors visibly.
- Do not confuse “someone in my network shared this” with “I personally endorse this company.”

4. A direct audience relationship

An opt-in email list is more durable than dependence on LinkedIn distribution. LinkedIn can remain the discovery and sharing layer, but the email letter should be the canonical product. Each issue should also have a public web version so people can forward a single opportunity or the whole edition.

5. A recognizable editorial ritual

Durability comes from a repeatable promise and cadence, not ever-expanding features. The format should be small enough to publish during a thin week and useful enough that readers open it even when they are not actively searching.

Where Dave's taste belongs

Taste is not "I like this company." It is a consistent set of questions applied to incomplete evidence.

The proposed editorial lens

For each opportunity, consider:

1. **Is this consequential analytics work?** Will the person influence a real decision, product or operating process?
2. **Is the role legible?** Can a candidate tell what success looks like, or is the description an undifferentiated wish list?
3. **Does the organization understand the craft?** Are analytics, analytics engineering and data engineering treated as distinct but collaborative capabilities?
4. **Is there room for a mid-career person to exercise judgment?** The audience is not looking merely to execute tickets or produce dashboards on demand.
5. **What human signals are present?** Who shared it? What do they know? Is the hiring manager identifiable? Is there evidence of respect for candidates and colleagues?
6. **What values are implicated?** What does the company make possible, for whom, and at whose expense? Are there material concerns the reader should investigate?
7. **Is the bargain plausible?** Where available: compensation, location, flexibility, scope, seniority and expectations.

The letter should not assign a synthetic score. Scores suggest a level of comparable evidence that will rarely exist. A concise editorial note is more honest and more distinctly Dave.

A useful annotation vocabulary

Each item can state:

- **Why it caught my eye** — Dave's interpretation.
- **What I know** — facts supplied by the posting or network contact.
- **What I would ask** — the unresolved question a serious candidate should investigate.
- **Connection available** — only when Dave has permission and a realistic path to introduce someone.

This makes taste visible without turning it into unsupported endorsement.

How the letter can differentiate

The core difference

Most job products optimize one or more of **volume, matching, application speed or employer reach**. This letter should optimize **attention, context and trust**.

Common product promise	Dave's alternative
"Thousands of current jobs"	"A few opportunities that reached people I know"
"Matched to your profile"	"Interpreted for experienced analytics practitioners"
"Apply faster"	"Decide more intelligently where to invest effort"
"Values-based employers"	"Concrete questions about the work, organization and consequences"
"Career content"	"One useful observation arising from this week's roles"
"Build your personal brand"	"Help good people and good teams find one another"

A position worth owning

The network note for thoughtful analytics careers.

This territory joins three things that competitors generally separate:

1. A defined craft community: mid-career analysts and analytics engineers.
2. Opportunities that arrive through human relationships.
3. Editorial judgment about both career fit and values.

The word **network** should mean provenance, not exclusivity. Some opportunities will already be public. Their value is that a trusted person surfaced them and may be able to add context—not that the letter possesses secret jobs.

Recommended product shape

Weekly issue

1. **A short opening note**
One observation from the week's conversations or roles.
2. **Three to eight opportunities**
Each includes role, organization, location/remote status, compensation when known, source link, why it caught Dave's eye, what is known, and what to ask.
3. **One network request**
For example: a hiring manager seeking a particular background, or a community member asking for an introduction. Publish only with permission.
4. **One durable resource**
A practical job-search tool, example, question or piece of advice—not a generic link roundup.
5. **Invitation to contribute**
"Send me a role you would be comfortable putting in front of people you respect."

Explicit exclusions

- No attempt to be comprehensive.
- No scraped or automatically generated filler.
- No entry-level focus.
- No generic data-science or software-engineering roles unless the actual work fits the audience.
- No paid placement during the trust-building phase.
- No guarantee that a listed organization is good or that a reader will receive an introduction.
- No private community, job tracker or application automation at launch.

The risks

Network exhaustion

A personal network may not yield enough relevant roles every week. The remedy is not scraping. Allow short editions, broaden contribution through trusted second-degree sources, and occasionally publish a market or craft note with no obligation to hit a listing quota.

Ambiguous endorsement

Readers may infer that Dave has vetted every employer. Use a consistent provenance line and a standing disclaimer: curation means “worth investigating,” not “guaranteed good.”

Values becoming vague or moralizing

“Aligned with your values” is personal; Dave cannot determine alignment for everyone. The editorial job is to surface evidence and questions, not issue moral certification.

Introductions becoming unmanageable

Do not promise an introduction for every role or subscriber. State clearly when an introduction may be possible, request a concise expression of interest, and preserve the contact’s permission and attention.

Becoming a job board

Structured listings, employer intake and sponsorship can slowly displace the voice and network. The governing test should be: **Would this change improve the reader’s judgment, or merely increase inventory?**

Serving two audiences

The reader is the primary customer even though the letter is free. Employers and network contacts are contributors. If their interests conflict, protect reader trust.

Six-week pilot

The concept can be tested manually before naming, branding or building software.

Before issue one

- Write a one-paragraph charter and the editorial lens.
- Ask 15–20 trusted people to forward appropriate roles.
- Establish a simple submission format: role link, how the sender knows the team, why it may be good, and whether an introduction is possible.
- Invite an initial group of mid-career analysts and analytics engineers directly.

During the pilot

- Publish on the same day each week.
- Cap each issue at eight roles; publish fewer when necessary.
- Personally annotate every role.
- Track replies, forwards, contributed roles, requests for introductions and reported outcomes.
- Ask one different feedback question at the end of each issue.

Evidence of promise

Subscriber count is a weak early metric. More meaningful signals are:

- Hiring managers and practitioners voluntarily send roles again.
- Readers forward the letter to people they respect.
- Readers reply with specific questions or context.
- Introductions lead to credible conversations.
- People continue reading when they are not actively applying.
- The letter sharpens Dave's own relationships and point of view.

Decision after six weeks

Continue if the supply of roles and reader engagement both appear relational rather than promotional. Adjust the cadence if quality supply is intermittent. Stop or reposition if most inventory must be scraped, or if the work feels like maintaining a board rather than exercising judgment and strengthening a community.

Recommended working language

One-sentence promise

Every week, I share a small selection of opportunities that have reached me through my network—hopefully helping mid-career data analysts and analytics engineers find work suited to their careers and values.

Slightly more specific version

A free weekly note for mid-career data analysts and analytics engineers: a few opportunities shared through my network, along with context on the work, the organization and the questions I think are worth asking.

Submission invitation

Hiring—or know someone who is? Send me an analytics role you would be comfortable putting in front of people you respect. Tell me how you know the team, why the work matters and whether you may be able to make an introduction.

Bottom line

Do not compete with job boards on inventory or software. Do not compete with career newsletters on content volume. Build a trusted weekly practice around a simple act: **people Dave respects send him opportunities; Dave applies informed taste; people doing thoughtful analytics work receive a useful signal.**

If that loop becomes habitual, the audience is not merely a mailing list. It becomes the tribe the project is intended to focus and serve.

Sources consulted

- [Analytics Engineering Jobs](#)
- [DataAnalyst.com](#)
- [Data Elixir](#)
- [dbt Labs: How to find a role in analytics engineering](#)
- [Locally Optimistic community](#)
- [Never Search Alone](#)
- [Tech Jobs for Good](#)
- [Welcome to the Jungle](#)